UNITY CATALOG · GA JULY 2026

ALL OR NOTHING

Wrap several SQL statements in one transaction. They commit together or they roll back together.

```
BEGIN ATOMIC ... END;
```

THE PROBLEM

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THREE STATEMENTS, THREE SEPARATE COMMITS

1. `UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance - 100 WHERE id = 1;`
   Ada is debited. Durable, on disk, irreversible.
   COMMITTED

2. `UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance + 100 WHERE id = 2;`
   Grace never gets the money.
   FAILED

3. `INSERT INTO transfer_log VALUES (1, 2, 100, now());`
   No audit trail of any of it.
   NEVER RAN

£100 left one account and reached nobody. Your tables now disagree, and you repair them by hand.

THE FIX

WRAP THEM AND THEY MOVE AS ONE

```sql
BEGIN ATOMIC
  UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance - 100.00 WHERE account_id = 1;
  UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance + 100.00 WHERE account_id = 2;
  INSERT INTO transfer_log
    VALUES (1, 2, 100.00, current_timestamp());
END;

-- Two tables. One commit. One Delta log entry.
```

🗄️ UC MANAGED TABLES

✅ CATALOG COMMITS ON

⚡ DBR 18.0+ OR SQL WAREHOUSE

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THE PROOF

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THE LAST STATEMENT FAILS. WATCH THE FIRST TWO VANISH.

```
BEGIN ATOMIC
  -- These two succeed...
  INSERT INTO transfer_log VALUES (2, 1, 5000.00, now());
  UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance + 5000.00 WHERE account_id = 1;

  -- ...then this trips CHECK (balance ⩾ 0)
  UPDATE accounts SET balance = balance - 5000.00 WHERE account_id = 2;
END;
```

ADA'S BALANCE	LOG ROWS	DELTA COMMITS
400.00	1	0
Credit undone	Insert undone	Nothing written

THE RULES

SIX THINGS TO GET RIGHT

🔓
Turn on catalog commits
delta.feature.catalogManaged = 'supported' on every table you write to.

🚫
No DDL inside
CREATE, ALTER and DROP run outside the transaction. So does time travel.

🎯
Prefer BEGIN ATOMIC
Row-level conflict detection and automatic rollback. No open session to leak.

🔄
Build retry logic
Commits are optimistic. Conflicts surface at commit time and the loser fails.

📸
Reads are repeatable
First touch pins a snapshot. Later reads ignore everyone else's commits.

⏱️
Know the ceilings
100 tables per transaction. Everything rolls back after 48 hours.

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STOP REPAIRING HALF-WRITTEN DATA

`BEGIN ATOMIC ... END;`

Full walkthrough → dailydatabricks.tips/s/transactions

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